

Beliefs about Seeking and Receiving Help: A Mixed-Methods Analysis

Supplementary Materials

Table of Contents

Study 1: Qualitative Identification of Recipient Beliefs	2
Qualitative Survey Instructions and Questions	2
Help Seeking Survey.....	2
Help Receiving Survey	3
Additional Comments on Procedure	5
Researcher Background	5
Reliability and Validity of Qualitative Data	6
Analytic Strategy	7
Results.....	9
Theme 1: Help is Useful	9
Theme 2: Help Process is Enjoyable (or Unpleasant).....	10
Theme 3: Help Reflects My Ability and Worth.....	12
Theme 4: Help Threatens my Independence.....	13
Theme 5: Helpers can be Relied on and Trusted	14
Comparison of Qualitative Themes with Previous Themes in the Literature	16
Study 2: EFA and CFA Results	18
Table 1: Help is Useful	18
Table 2: Help Process is Enjoyable or Unpleasant	18
Table 3: Help Reflects My Ability and Worth.....	19
Table 4: Help Threatens My Independence	19
Table 6: One-factor CFA Fit Statistics for Belief Scales.....	20
Refined Belief Definitions and Finalized Scale Items	21
Study 3: Correlations and RWA Results	24
Table 1: Means, Standard Deviations, and Correlations between Variables	24
Table 2: Results of Multiple Regression and Relative Weight Analysis	25
References.....	29

Study 1: Qualitative Identification of Recipient Beliefs

Qualitative Survey Instructions and Questions

Help Seeking Survey

Please read the following instructions carefully:

In this study, we are interested in **understanding people's experiences of seeking help**. We are interested in understanding experiences of seeking help for things in day-to-day life. For example, people might ask for help to complete a chore or a task, understand instructions, handle emergencies, or navigate stressful situations. Sometimes, when people need help, they choose to ask for it from friends, family members, colleagues, acquaintances, or even strangers. Other times, people need help but may decide not to ask for it.

In the following survey, you will be asked to describe some of your thoughts and experiences about seeking help. These questions (6 in total) are all **open-ended**, meaning that you will have to **write out your answers rather than click response options**. We understand that this will take **significantly more effort on your part**, but it will allow us to **understand your experiences** in a way that is not captured by numerical rating scales. You may have more to say in response to some questions than others- and that's okay! Your thoughtful responses to these questions are greatly appreciated. Please do not worry too much about spelling or grammar; just try to answer each question as best as you can. If you would like to edit a response to a previous question you can do so by selecting the "back" arrow before finishing the survey.

Payment of completed surveys: The responses you give will be reviewed before accepting the HIT in MTurk. Only responses that give clear, detailed descriptions from your own experience/perspective will be accepted. Vague responses that don't give the details asked for (e.g., speaking in generalities when asked to provide a specific example from your own experience), fail to answer the questions posed, or responses that have copied random text from other sources will result in the HIT being rejected.

Importantly, if you do not want to devote the necessary effort to answer these questions, **please do not go on to the rest of the survey**. We are looking for **thoughtful responses that include important details**. If you are willing to put in this effort, **we would be very glad to have you complete this survey**. We greatly value your thoughtful contributions to this research.

Questions:

1. In general, how would you describe your **thoughts and feelings** about **seeking help**? Please share at least 1-2 sentences.

Now, we would like you to think about your experiences of *seeking* help. Remember, we are interested in the kinds of experiences that occur somewhat regularly in our day-to-day life. Therefore, please try to think of experiences that have occurred within the past month.

2. Please take 1-2 minutes to think about a **recent experience where you needed help and decided to ask for help**. When ready, **please write several complete sentences and**

describe what happened in as much detail as possible. For example, what help you needed and why, why you decided to ask for help, whom you asked and how they responded, and how you felt.

3. Please take 1-2 minutes to think about a **recent situation where you *needed* help, but decided *not to ask* for help.** When ready, **please write several complete sentences, and describe what happened in as much detail as possible.** For example, what help did you need, and why did you decide not to ask for help?
4. What do you think are some of the **main reasons** why other people might **decide to ask for help**? Please list at least two or three reasons.
5. What do you think are some of the **main reasons** why other people might **avoid asking for help (i.e., decide not to ask for help)**? Please list at least two or three reasons.
6. Is there **anything else you would like to share** with us about seeking help?

Help Receiving Survey

Please read the following instructions carefully:

In this study, we are interested in **understanding people's experiences of *receiving* help.** We are interested in understanding experiences of receiving help within people's regular daily life. For example, someone might help you complete your chores or a task, understand information, handle emergencies, or navigate a challenging situation. Sometimes, this is in response to asking for help. Other times, we may receive help without having asked for it.

In the following survey, you will be asked to describe some of your thoughts and experiences about *receiving* help. These questions (6 in total) are all **open-ended**, meaning that you will have to **write out your answers rather than click response options.** We understand that this will take **significantly more effort on your part**, but it will allow us to **understand your experiences** in a way that is not captured by numerical rating scales. You may have more to say in response to some questions than others- and that's okay! Your thoughtful responses to these questions are greatly appreciated. Please do not worry too much about spelling or grammar; just try to answer each question as best as you can. If you would like to edit a response to a previous question you can do so by selecting the "back" arrow before finishing the survey.

Payment of completed surveys: The responses you give will be reviewed before accepting the HIT in MTurk. Only responses that give clear, detailed descriptions from your own experience/perspective will be accepted. Vague responses that don't give the details asked for (e.g., speaking in generalities when asked to provide a specific example from your own experience), fail to answer the questions posed, or responses that have copied random text from other sources will result in the HIT being rejected.

Importantly, if you do not want to devote the necessary effort to answer these questions, **please do not go on to the rest of the survey**. We are looking for **thoughtful responses that include important details**. If you are willing to put in this effort, **we would be very glad to have you complete this survey**. We greatly value your thoughtful contributions to this research.

Questions:

1. In general, how would you describe your **thoughts and feelings** about **receiving help**? Please share at least 1-2 sentences.

Now, we would like you to think about your experiences of *receiving* help. Remember, we are interested in the kinds of experiences that occur somewhat regularly in our day-to-day life. Therefore, please try to think of experiences that have occurred within the past month.

2. Please take 1-2 minutes to think about a **recent time when someone did something for you that you found to be helpful**. (It may be help that someone offered and you accepted, or from a situation where you asked for help.) When ready, **please write several complete sentences and include as much detail as possible**. Describe in detail what happened, who helped you, what they did, why it was helpful, and how you felt.
3. Please take 1-2 minutes to think about a **recent time when someone helped you, but it did not feel very helpful to you (perhaps it was even unhelpful)**. When ready, **please write several complete sentences and include as much detail as possible**. Describe in detail what happened, who helped you, what they did, why it was less helpful than you would wish, and how you felt.
4. What do you think are some of the **main reasons** why other people might ***accept* an offer of help**? Please list at least two or three reasons.
5. What do you think are some of the **main reasons** why other people might ***refuse* an offer of help**? Please list at least two or three reasons.
6. Is there **anything else you would like to share with us** about receiving help?

Additional Comments on Procedure

Participants were informed that the study involves providing written responses to several questions about their experiences of seeking (receiving) help. Participants were asked to complete the survey on a computer (desktop or laptop), not a tablet or smartphone, since the questions require typed responses. If interested in participating, participants were able to access the survey through a Qualtrics link provided. After providing informed consent, participants were given detailed instructions for the survey, following suggestions from Braun et al. (2021; e.g., participants were encouraged not to worry about correct spelling or grammar and instructed to take time to think before responding). After pilot testing the survey, a question was added, giving participants the opportunity to opt out of the study if they were not interested in putting in the effort to provide written responses to the open-ended questions. After reading a description of seeking (receiving) help in day-to-day life, participants were directed to respond to open-ended questions. Character limits, ranging from 2-100, were set for each question. Participants had to reach the minimum response before they could move on to the next question.

Researcher Background

I (the first author) conducted all the analysis of this study as part of my master's thesis project, starting the second summer of my graduate studies. This was my first study involving qualitative coding of participant data. I received qualitative training through a graduate-level qualitative research methods class through the College of Education at Purdue University.

While previous literature informed my understanding of recipient beliefs, I did not try to apply any previous framework or labels from previous work in data analysis. Once the themes were developed, as one of the final stages of reviewing and refining my themes, I compared them to previous scale items (see Comparison of Qualitative Themes with Previous Themes in the Literature).

Reliability and Validity of Qualitative Data

For qualitative analysis, reliability (or consistency) is the issue of how consistent the results are with the data that was collected while validity (or credibility) concerns the relationship of the findings to reality (or rather, the participant's constructions of reality; Merriam & Tisdell, 2016).

In qualitative research, reliability, validity, and more broadly, the trustworthiness of the researcher and results are evaluated in numerous ways. For this study, I maintained an audit trail of every research decision, from the time I started testing different survey questions with family members, and throughout data collection and analysis. This record served the basis for describing the method process, and was helpful for continued reflection throughout the analysis. I collected data in small increments throughout a three-month time period, during that time and for about a month following I spent an average of approximately 10 hours analyzing my data each week. As two forms of peer review/examination, the second author was involved in regular discussions throughout this process, as part of my reflection on my themes. A recent PhD graduate with experience in qualitative research also provided multiple rounds of feedback on the developing themes. Then, once my analysis seemed clear and near its final form, I involved a second coder for some excerpts, and used their feedback and our discussion for further reflection and refinement of the themes.

For the sake of transparency, I provide detailed descriptions of the sample, data collection, and analytic strategy, and incorporate participant quotations throughout the results to allow readers to evaluate the quality of the study (Levitt et al., 2018). I assume that all humans have some level of beliefs about help; therefore, sampling was not targeted to individuals with a very particular type of experience. This is both a strength and limitation of this study, in that I recruited through MTurk, which is more representative of the population than a student sample,

but still only included participants within the United States. The consistency of these beliefs across other cultural populations will be an area for future research.

Analytic Strategy

For analysis method, I followed guidelines for Thematic Analysis (Braun & Clarke, 2006, 2019), which is a flexible approach to qualitative analysis that seeks to identify patterns of meaning across a data set. The primary research question was: *What beliefs do people hold about seeking and receiving help?*

Qualitative data analysis is an iterative process. Analysis was performed by cycling through numerous steps. First, the responses from an individual participant were read as a whole, before creating initial codes. Meaningful units of text were coded with a word or phrase to capture its perceived meaning (Chenail, 2012; Saldaña, 2013). I used many kinds of codes (e.g., descriptive, in vivo, values). Excerpts of text with similar meanings were assigned the same code. Aside from coding the data, I also kept an audit trail to record coding decisions and thoughts throughout the process. I also made memos in NVivo, especially when the meaning in a piece of the text seemed particularly ambiguous or open to multiple interpretations. In these situations, simultaneous coding was also used (Saldaña, 2013). As the coding process was inductive, the codes used were also refined over time. I gradually wrote and refined definitions for each code. In this process, codes were also relabeled, split into more specific sub-codes, or combined.

As codes were developed and more data gathered, the next step was developing themes (Braun & Clarke, 2006). The process of developing the themes was also iterative and occurred alongside data collection and coding. It started with grouping codes into categories that had similar meanings. For example, an early category was called “accessing help” and included

codes “availability or lack of support,” “hard to get help,” and “offered help.” Early on, I was focused on different “referents” of the codes, such as the helper, recipient, or something else; however, there was considerable overlap between concepts that were reflective of different referents (e.g., recipient’s worried about placing a “burden” on a helper, and were also concerned about “being a burden” themselves). Discussion with the second author led me to adjust my themes to focus more on the similarity in content rather than the target. Eventually, this led to five major themes, which were consistent with the coded extracts.

These themes and subthemes were named and defined (Braun & Clarke, 2006) and revised based on feedback from peers. Besides discussion with the second author, some feedback was solicited from a recent psychology PhD graduate who had experience in qualitative analysis. As an additional part of this process, 50 excerpts were given to a second coder, along with the five theme definitions (which included positive and negative wording and a brief statement as to what should *not* be included in that theme). The second coder was a post-bac research assistant at the time. We met to discuss the themes, and then the second coder labeled all the excerpts with the theme they best matched, and sometimes indicated two themes. The secondary coder identified the same theme as the original codes 78% of the time. The theme with the lowest agreement was 50%, and the highest was 100%. We met to go over all the cases with disagreement and discussed them until we reached consensus. Through this process, I identified wording in one of the themes that was not specific enough and had made it a “broad” category that caught many codes. There were also instances in which both coders agreed that multiple themes were present; the one selected depended on the part of the data focused on. In two cases, the discussion pointed to a lack of distinction in subthemes across the themes. In these cases, the data were re-coded, and definitions were rewritten to be more internally consistent and distinct.

Results

Theme 1: Help is Useful

This theme describes beliefs about the necessity of help, the helper's ability to give useful help, and whether the benefits will outweigh the costs, or the consequences if help is not received. This theme reflects the belief that help serves a practical function in fulfilling needs and/or improving outcomes (e.g., achieving a goal or completing a task). Some participants shared that there are situations in life where "it's necessary and required to receive help" (e.g., "they can't do the task themselves", "to prevent injury" or when they "do not have the necessary knowledge"). Some participants believed they should only seek/accept help if they "exhausted all other options" and help is the "last resort". Many believed that help should be refused when you "don't really need it." However, some saw the benefits of receiving, even without a real need.

Some participants compared their needs to the knowledge, skills, or ability of potential helpers to determine whether help would be useful. Help was perceived as beneficial when the helper could meet the situational need (e.g., "his help made a huge difference, since he's strong"), but was less useful, or rejected, if the helper could not meet the requirements (e.g., "the person trying to help might not be able to help due to weakness or something else").

Finally, beliefs about the usefulness of help were manifested in participants' expectations about the outcomes of seeking or receiving help. Some pointed to the negative costs, such as the effort needed to explain a problem, tasks that could take longer with more people involved, or the belief that help "makes things worse." There are also possible negative consequences of *not* seeking/receiving help. For example, in one woman's experience, "Because [I did not seek help]... I have developed long-lasting wrist pain." Many identified practical benefits, such as

protection from negative consequences (e.g., “I ended up being happy with not ending up hurt or killed”), saving “time” and “money,” and solving problems.

Theme 2: Help Process is Enjoyable (or Unpleasant)

This theme contains beliefs about the experience of seeking or receiving help; specifically, whether it will be positive and enjoyable, or negative and unpleasant, for both the recipient and the potential helper.

Participants who had positive beliefs about seeking help felt confident in knowing when and how to ask, viewing it as an opportunity to connect with others (e.g., “asking for help... can make a friendship stronger”). Subthemes help included confidence in their request (e.g., “request is reasonable,” “it’s appropriate”), and their ability to ask in a manner that will be acceptable to the helper (e.g., “asking for help gently and politely”). However, more participants expressed negative beliefs and emotions about seeking help (e.g., “I do not like to ask for help; it makes me feel a lot of anxiety”). They felt that it would be challenging to ask (“a really difficult thing to do”) and felt that they did not “know how to ask” or might be asking “too much.” Some participants believed that in order to ask for help, they would need to have something to offer in exchange. For example, one participant shared:

I told a friend they could have an old weight bench that was just taking up space in my house, and he agreed to help me get the junk out of that room so I could fix it up. As soon as he got the weight bench in his truck he said he had to go. He was running late and was sorry. So I was stuck clearing the room myself and had nothing to offer somebody else to help.

Some participants also expressed concern over the recipient’s experience, and felt that asking for help would “burden” or “impose” on others, and they “don’t want to cause problems.”

Participants more frequently made positive evaluations about the experience of receiving help rather than seeking help. A key subtheme involved the relational component of help. Some appreciated receiving help because it was enjoyable to “do something with another person” and saw receiving help as “a matter of just spending some quality time with someone”. Some also reported liking the helper more or feeling “more connected” during the process. Another subtheme was the belief that helping makes the helper feel “happy” and “helpful,” and therefore receiving help was something that some people did because they cared about the helper. Some people expressed positive beliefs around reciprocity, and did not mind receiving help because they had helped others in the past, or they felt that it inspired them to help others “in the future.” Some participants also reflected on paying back the help in tangible ways such as returning a borrowed car with a full gas tank, or “helping in return.” This could also include the expression of gratitude. While many participants expressed the emotion of feeling “grateful” after receiving help, some participants discussed the expression of gratitude as part of the recipient’s role when receiving help.

However, some participants did not appreciate the social interaction of receiving help and expressed a “desire to be alone.” They also believed that at times that they had to receive help because it would be “rude to turn it down” or they may “feel obligated to accept.” Some expressed a belief that helping was burdensome and unpleasant to the helper, and they “don’t want to put someone out” or take “time away” from them. Relatedly, they expressed caution over “taking others for granted” and felt concerned that they could “get too comfortable” receiving help and not recognize the helper’s efforts.

Theme 3: Help Reflects My Ability and Worth

This theme reflects recipient beliefs that needing, seeking, or receiving help will influence evaluations made of themselves and their worth. This theme reflects the ways that a recipient may perceive their own value and ability, and their concern for how they may appear to others.

When a recipient believes that seeking/receiving help says something negative about them, it tends to be harsher than the other themes. For example, instead of believing that helping is a burden to the helper, some recipients believe *they* are the burden. Instead of needing help because they do not know something, recipients felt instead that they are “stupid” or “incompetent.” Some also believed that accepting or seeking help made them “weak and incapable” or “helpless.” They may also question their worthiness to receive help, feeling like they “do not deserve” it. Very few people expressed positive views of themselves as recipients of help. However, one shared, “I do not think that I am annoying,” and another that “receiving help can make us feel appreciated and purposeful.”

Furthermore, seeking and receiving help can stir up concern about how the recipient will be perceived by the helper or anyone else who observes the situation. Participants shared that they do not want “to seem needy” or “appear weak,” and they are “afraid a person might view them completely different.” Instead, they felt like doing a task themselves would make them “appear competent” and “impress others.” Only one person expressed that they were not afraid of being judged, and a couple of others thought that it “shows strength to admit that you need some sort of help.”

Finally, some participants shared beliefs about whether or not receiving help is normal, and if they were normal for receiving help. Those who believe that help is normal believe help is “something we all need once in a while.” However, some people expressed feeling that they

were *not* normal for needing help. For example, one felt “broken to not do things for myself.” Another expressed embarrassment asking for help when lost, believing that “no one does that these days.”

Theme 4: Help Threatens my Independence

This theme expresses beliefs about the importance of independence to a recipients’ sense of self, or the belief that it is important and desirable to be independent, and that seeking and receiving help threatens that independence. This theme reflects the importance of independence to an individual’s identity or way of life. Some believed figuring it out yourself is important for *appearing* independent in a society that values independence. Within this theme, participants expressed an appreciation for relying on themselves, a preference for their own way of doing things, and a distaste for relying on others.

Participants expressed independence as part of their identity (e.g., “I’m very self-sufficient”), which stops them from seeking help. For example, one participant shared, “I have never been one to ask for help in most situations in life. I have always been an independent thinker and doer.” Independent people are “confident they can do it themselves,” and they “don’t want to depend on others.”

Some participants expressed the pleasure of “figuring things out” on their own; receiving help can take away that opportunity to solve it yourself. Participants who “believe they can find an answer” or “want to learn how to do something themselves” will persist on a problem for some time without seeking help. Some participants believed that it was only appropriate to receive help after trying first to work out the problem themselves; even then, some saw asking for help as meaning, “I have failed at doing it myself,” and felt bad (e.g., “guilty” or

“disheartened”). Similarly, some people believed that “the only person who could do the task right is themselves.”

Some held so strongly to their belief in the importance of independence, that they would persist in a task, even after facing their own lack. One woman, describing an instance where she did not ask for help, understood that it would have been reasonable to seek help, and yet she kept working on the problem herself: “I wracked my brain for a week trying to figure out what I was doing wrong instead of doing *what any sensible person would do* and bounce ideas off of my colleagues. [Emphasis added.]”

Some participants discussed dependence as a negative characteristic of recipients that might lead them to receive more help. Some people may seek/receive help because they are “lazy and want people to do their work for them,” or they “[lack] confidence in their own abilities” and “want reassurance.” or are “desperate” and “incapable of taking care of themselves,” reflecting a dependent nature. Non-independent people may also be “selfish,” “entitled,” and willing to “[take] advantage of others.” In most instances, participants discussed dependence when reflecting on why “other people” would seek or receive help.

Theme 5: Helpers can be Relied on and Trusted

This theme reflects participants’ belief in potential helpers’ willingness and motives for helping, as well as the history or relationship they need to have with someone in order to trust that they will help. Some believed that helpers “truly want to help” and are “willing to help.” Whereas participants who expressed a lack of trust in helpers felt that others were “not willing to help”, or only helped out of a sense of obligation, and would therefore be “annoyed” or “resentful” when asked to help. Some participants discussed ideas reflecting their awareness that helpers have a choice whether or not to help. Participants with higher trust usually remained

confident that a potential helper would be willing to work things out to be able to help. However, some participants did not have this kind of confidence. One shared, “I always feel a little nervous to ask for help because I do not think that I will get the answer that I want.”

Participants who believed that helpers are trustworthy expressed confidence in the helper’s motivations: they believed that people help because they truly “care”, feeling that “it comes from a good place and from the heart.” Participants who believed that helpers were untrustworthy doubted their motives for helping. They believed that a helper might help in order to get what they want from a situation, to look good in front of others, or to get something in return. One participant shared that she struggled to ask for help because “I always wonder what they will want in return,” and another that “some folks...‘help’ uninvited in order to get payment or to look for a returned favor.”

Finally, some people believed that they could only rely on helpers with whom they have a positive history. Participants expressed greater trust in helpers with whom they had a close relationship or past experiences (e.g., “whatever it may be I will ask my friend”). These beliefs could be particular to a relationship, but past experiences also shaped participants’ beliefs about helpers and help in general. Some experiences with helpers made recipients “feel better about asking for help,” Whereas others lead people to avoid that helper in the future, or help in general.

Comparison of Qualitative Themes with Previous Themes in the Literature

Theme	Concepts/Measures that have content overlap with the theme	New content in current theme
Help is Useful	• Coworker Incompetence Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018): • All items reverse scored “competence”; some overlap with Helper KSAOs, but narrower content • Network Orientation Scale (Vaux et al., 1986): • 3 items relate to Need of Help, 1 related to Help Outcomes • Autonomous Logics of Action (Geller & Bamberger, 2012): • Items are very behavioral, but some include ability of helper, and potential outcomes of help	• Broader representation of when it is appropriate to need help, and both positive and negative outcomes expected from receiving help- minimal overlap with past scales
Help Process is Enjoyable (or Unpleasant)	• Reciprocity Obligation Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018) • Narrower context/reciprocity as negative • Network Orientation Scale (Vaux et al., 1986) • A couple items similar to positive experience of seeking help	• Specifically includes seeking and receiving • Positive beliefs (e.g., quality time, helper will feel good, inspires future helping, paying it forward)
Help Reflects My Ability and Worth	• Self-Stigma of Seeking Help Scale (Vogel et al., 2006) • Similar to self-evaluations, but more hypothetical vs. belief framed • Perception of Stigmatization by Others for Seeking Help (Vogel & Wade, 2009) • Overlaps with What Others Think, though includes different “judgments” (e.g., seriously disturbed/a risk) • Help-Seeking Threat (Karabenick & Knapp, 1991) • Some overlap with Self-Evaluations and What Others Think	• Positive beliefs (e.g., value and strength) • Receiving is common to everyone vs. unique to me

	• Stigma Scale for Receiving Psychological Help (Komiya et al., 2000) • Broad; some overlap with what others think • Diminished Image Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018) • Mostly about managers perceptions, similar to What Others Think	
Help Threatens My Independence	• Self-Reliance Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018) • Narrower than independence • Coworker Incompetence Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018) • One item suggesting that my performance standards are higher • Dependent Logics of Action (Geller & Bamberger, 2012) • Some overlap with dependence, such as preferring to rely on someone else • Self-stigma of Seeking Help Scale (Vogel et al., 2006) • Some overlap- e.g., “if I could not solve my own problems”	• Independence as part of one’s identity • Broader and more specific content (e.g., confidence, effort)
Helpers can be Relied on and Trusted	• Coworker Mistrust Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018) • Similar to general Untrustworthiness, and Ulterior Motives • Reciprocity Obligation Belief (Thompson & Bolino, 2018) • Expecting help to be repaid is similar to Ulterior Motives • Network Orientation Scale (Vaux et al., 1986) • Careful who you share with/ trusting others, some items represent History, or Distrust of Motives	• Willingness/resentment of helper • Helper’s choice to help • Positive motives (e.g., showing care)

Study 2: EFA and CFA Results

Table 1: Help is Useful

Item	Factor 1	h^2
Few people have the skills needed to give good help	.59	.35
Others who are unskilled will make things worse if they help	.55	.30
Things take longer with help than it takes to do them yourself	.66	.44
In many situations, help makes things worse	.73	.54
There is not much point in asking for help	.72	.52
Getting help causes more trouble than it is worth	.85	.73
I need help when I am struggling	-.42	.17
Help is useful for achieving my goals	-.44	.20
Proportion Explained Variance		40.70%
Eigenvalue		3.78

Note. The eigenvalue of the second, un-retained factor was 1.11. $N = 367$. h^2 = communality coefficient.

Table 2: Help Process is Enjoyable or Unpleasant

Item	Factor 1	h^2
Asking for help is enjoyable	-.72	.52
Asking for help is difficult	.80	.65
Asking for help puts a burden on the helper	.75	.57
It is intimidating to ask for help	.63	.40
It is uncomfortable to receive help	.77	.60
Asking for help is a way to form new friendships	-.50	.25
Receiving help inspires me to help others	-.40	.16
Receiving help makes me more connected to others	-.53	.28
Proportion Explained Variance		42.90%
Eigenvalue		3.94

Note. The eigenvalue of the second, un-retained factor was 1.48. $N = 367$. h^2 = communality coefficient.

Table 3: Help Reflects My Ability and Worth

Item	Factor 1	h^2
Others will think I am incompetent if I ask for help	.81	.66
People will judge me for seeking help	.80	.64
Asking for help makes me appear needy to others	.80	.63
Seeking help is showing weakness to others	.84	.70
Accepting help makes me feel worse about myself	.81	.66
Asking for help makes me a burden to others	.82	.67
It shows strength to admit that you need help	-.59	.35
Asking for help shows that I am cooperative	-.57	.32
Receiving help shows me that I am valued	-.50	.25
Receiving help increases my capacity	-.55	.30
Proportion Explained Variance	51.90%	
Eigenvalue	5.61	

Note. The eigenvalue of the second, un-retained factor was 1.37. $N = 367$. h^2 = communality coefficient.

Table 4: Help Threatens My Independence

Item	Factor 1	h^2
If you want something done right, you need to do it yourself	.72	.51
I am better off doing things alone than accepting help	.81	.66
I will lose my independence if I let people help me	.69	.47
Receiving help means I failed to figure it out myself	.67	.44
I am too stubborn to ask for help	.65	.43
I should not have to depend on anyone for what I need	.67	.45
Proportion Explained Variance	49.40%	
Eigenvalue	3.46	

Note. The eigenvalue of the second, un-retained factor was 0.76. $N = 367$. h^2 = communality coefficient.

Table 5: Helpers can be Relied on and Trusted

Item	Factor 1	h^2
Others are genuinely willing to help me	.75	.56
Others will find a way of helping me that will work for both of us	.66	.43
I can be confident that people will help me when I need it	.67	.44
Others gladly choose to help me	.83	.68
People help me because they care about me	.65	.42
People have ulterior motives for helping me	-.64	.41
People help me because they want something from me	-.62	.39
People only help me to make themselves look good	-.58	.34
Proportion Explained Variance	46.00%	
Eigenvalue	4.20	

Note. The eigenvalue of the second, un-retained factor was 1.31. $N = 367$. h^2 = communality coefficient

Table 6: One-factor CFA Fit Statistics for Belief Scales

Scale	# items	df	χ^2	CFI	RMSEA [90% CI]	SRMR	α
Help is Useful <i>There is not much point in asking for help (.76)</i> <i>Getting help causes more trouble than it is worth (.75)</i>	7	14	35.63*	.96	.079[.047, .112]	.048	.81
Help Process is Unpleasant <i>Asking for help is difficult (.80)</i> <i>It is uncomfortable to receive help (.79)</i>	6	9	34.28*	.96	.093[.061, .127]	.041	.84
Help Diminishes Me <i>Others will think I am incompetent if I ask for help (.87)</i> <i>Asking for help makes me appear needy to others (.85)</i>	6	9	51.77*	.95	.129[.096, .164]	.051	.88
Help Threatens my Independence <i>I am better off doing things alone than accepting help (.82)</i> <i>I will lose my independence if I let people help me (.70)</i>	4	2	0.10	1.00	.000[.000, .000]	.003	.80
Helpers are Trustworthy <i>Others gladly choose to help me (.82)</i> <i>Others are genuinely willing to help me (.81)</i>	5	5	17.66*	.98	.097[.050, .148]	.027	.87

Note. χ^2 , CFI, TLI, and RMSEA are robust estimates. The two highest loading items and their standardized loadings are presented in italics. $N = 368$. * $p \leq .05$

Refined Belief Definitions and Finalized Scale Items

Instructions for Participants:

“We want to understand your thoughts about seeking and receiving help in general. There is no right or wrong answer. For each item below, please indicate how well that statement represents your personal beliefs on a scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).”

At the top of each page, participants should be reminded of the item stem “I believe...”

Theme definitions were not provided to participants.

Scoring: The scale for each theme is scored by reversing all the items indicated with “(R)”, and then calculating the average score for those items. Each theme is scored so that a higher score indicates a stronger belief consistent with the wording of the theme (i.e., some are scored so that a higher score represents a positive belief, such as Help is Useful, and some are scored so that a higher score represents a negative belief, such as Help Diminishes Me).

Help is Useful: Belief that help serves a practical function in fulfilling needs and/or improving outcomes (e.g., achieving a goal or completing a task).

1. Things take longer with help than it takes to do them yourself (R)
2. In many situations, help makes things worse (R)
3. There is not much point in asking for help (R)
4. Getting help causes more trouble than it is worth (R)
5. I need help when I am struggling

Help Process is Enjoyable: Belief that the experience of seeking or receiving help will be positive and enjoyable for oneself and/or the helper.

1. Asking for help is enjoyable
2. Asking for help is difficult (R)
3. Asking for help puts a burden on the helper (R)
4. It is intimidating to ask for help (R)
5. It is uncomfortable to receive help (R)

Help Diminishes Me: Belief that needing, seeking or receiving help reflects negatively on my ability and worth.

1. People will judge me for seeking help
2. Asking for help makes me appear needy to others
3. Seeking help is showing weakness to others
4. Asking for help makes me a burden to others
5. It shows strength to admit that you need help (R)
6. Receiving help increases my capacity (R)

Help Threatens My Independence: Belief that independence is an important part of who I am, or it is important to be independent, and both seeking and receiving help go against my independence.

1. If you want something done right, you need to do it yourself
2. I am better off doing things alone than accepting help
3. I will lose my independence if I let people help me
4. I should not have to depend on anyone for what I need

Helpers are Trustworthy: Belief that other people are willing to help and have good and caring motives for helping.

1. Others are genuinely willing to help me
2. I can be confident that people will help me when I need it
3. Others gladly choose to help me
4. People help me because they care about me
5. People have ulterior motives for helping me (R)

Study 3: Correlations and RWA Results

Table 1: Means, Standard Deviations, Reliabilities, and Correlations between Variables

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16	17	18	19	20	21	22	23
1. T1 Helpful	3.57	0.86	.81																						
2. T1 Enjoyable	2.75	1.00	.43	.83																					
3. T1 Lessens	2.76	0.92	-.69	-.67	.84																				
4. T1 indePendence	3.11	1.00	-.67	-.61	.74	.80																			
5. T1 Safe	3.66	0.82	.58	.56	-.71	-.57	.83																		
6. T2 Helpful	3.58	0.81	.77	.34	-.63	-.57	.55	.79																	
7. T2 Enjoyable	2.79	1.02	.41	.78	-.65	-.52	.56	.51	.87																
8. T2 Lessens	2.67	0.95	-.65	-.58	.83	.67	-.62	-.73	-.74	.86															
9. T2 indePendence	3.10	1.02	-.62	-.48	.70	.74	-.55	-.73	-.63	.80	.84														
10. T2 Safe	3.69	0.78	.47	.46	-.62	-.48	.80	.59	.58	-.66	-.57	.82													
11. Help-Seeking	2.04	1.43	.10	.17	-.14	-.04	.22	.11	.17	-.12	-.04	.15	-												
12. Help Received	2.29	0.94	-.02	.35	-.14	-.02	.28	.04	.34	-.11	-.03	.24	.45	.98											
13. Life Satisfaction	3.26	1.13	.22	.51	-.43	-.33	.49	.24	.53	-.40	-.29	.46	.24	.47	.92										
14. Positive Affect	3.63	0.94	.23	.50	-.45	-.32	.50	.31	.55	-.46	-.29	.54	.26	.52	.76	.94									
15. Negative Affect	1.89	0.85	-.26	-.56	.45	.35	-.46	-.29	-.57	.42	.28	-.51	-.07	-.19	-.57	-.69	.92								
16. Extraversion	3.15	1.01	.19	.50	-.37	-.21	.33	.17	.47	-.31	-.12	.37	.25	.40	.53	.56	-.48	.81							
17. Agreeableness	3.95	0.87	.44	.38	-.49	-.43	.52	.53	.44	-.49	-.44	.53	.18	.25	.41	.50	-.48	.37	.85						
18. Openness	3.73	0.89	.26	.08	-.26	-.20	.22	.24	.13	-.24	-.20	.31	.00	-.02	-.00	.01	.02	.29	.25	.78					
19. Conscientiousness	4.07	0.82	.29	.48	-.41	-.34	.41	.27	.41	-.36	-.26	.43	.08	.13	.44	.43	-.51	.53	.52	.34	.83				
20. Neuroticism	2.18	1.07	-.27	-.54	.44	.31	-.47	-.31	-.52	.42	.24	-.47	-.11	-.17	-.51	-.56	.66	-.62	-.52	-.13	-.61	.89			
21. Self-Esteem	3.18	0.85	.29	.59	-.51	-.38	.49	.34	.61	-.49	-.30	.53	.23	.31	.68	.67	-.69	.62	.51	.08	.56	-.73	.94		
22. Age	39.82	11.74	.10	-.04	-.14	-.06	.06	.11	-.03	-.18	-.10	.10	-.09	-.22	-.04	-.02	-.07	.06	.15	.16	.10	-.19	.12	-	
23. Sex	0.40	0.49	.02	.04	-.03	-.05	.02	-.02	-.07	.01	-.01	-.07	.07	.12	.19	.16	.00	-.00	.12	-.11	.03	.09	.05	.13	-
24. Subjective SES	5.07	2.00	-.04	.36	-.15	-.03	.27	-.01	.33	-.04	.01	.22	.28	.58	.63	.57	-.39	.42	.23	-.09	.24	-.31	.45	-.19	.09

Note. *M* and *SD* are used to represent mean and standard deviation, respectively. Values on the diagonal are Cronbach's alpha reliability estimates. *N* = 192. Helpful = Help is Useful, Enjoyable = Help is Enjoyable, Lessens = Help Diminishes Me, indePendence = Help Threatens My Independence, Safe = Helpers can be Trusted, T1 = Time 1, T2 = Time 2.

Table 2: Results of Multiple Regression and Relative Weight Analysis

Predictor	<i>b</i>	β	RW	Sign	CI-L	CI-U	RS-RW (%)
Criterion = Help Seeking Behavior ¹ ($R^2 = .0707$; $F[5,185] = 2.81$, $p = .018$)							
Helpful	.071	.042	.005	+	-.022	.019	7.08
Enjoyable	.221	.156	.018	+	-.008	.074	25.86
Lessens	-.016	-.010	.009	-	-.021	.024	12.49
indePendence	.308	.215	.008	+	-.018	.028	11.50
Safe	.380*	.220	.030*	+	.001	.076	43.07
Criterion = Help Received ($R^2 = .2376$; $F[5,186] = 11.59$, $p < .001$)							
Helps	-.182	-.165	.017	-	-.011	.048	7.32
Enjoyable	.433*	.460	.111*	+	.051	.185	46.60
Lessens	.097	.094	.021	-	-.018	.029	8.84
indePendence	.261*	.276	.024	+	-.007	.046	9.94
Safe	.388*	.339	.065*	+	.015	.118	27.31
Criterion = Life Satisfaction ($R^2 = .3420$; $F[5,186] = 19.33$, $p < .001$)							
Helpful	-.250*	-.190	.015	-	-.050	-.024	4.45
Enjoyable	.379*	.337	.124*	+	.026	.143	36.24
Lessens	-.139	-.113	.059	-	-.011	.041	17.23
indePendence	.041	.036	.029	-	-.040	-.002	8.40
Safe	.486*	.355	.115*	+	.006	.123	33.67
Criterion = Positive Affect ($R^2 = .3487$; $F[5,186] = 19.92$, $p < .001$)							
Helpful	-.184	-.168	.016	-	-.007	.033	4.58
Enjoyable	.303*	.323	.120*	+	.063	.187	34.34

Lessens	-.186	-.181	.069*	-	.030	.118	19.74
indePendence	.098	.104	.026*	-	.006	.049	7.38
Safe	.400*	.350	.119*	+	.052	.203	34.00
Criterion = Negative Affect ($R^2 = .3532$; $F[5,186] = 20.32$, $p < .001$)							
Helpful	.088	.090	.015	-	-.002	.038	4.15
Enjoyable	-.379*	-.447	.167*	-	.105	.244	47.37
Lessens	.100	.107	.060*	+	.026	.101	17.09
indePendence	-.064	-.075	.030*	+	.010	.058	8.51
Safe	-.233*	-.226	.081*	-	.036	.146	22.87

Note. *b* unstandardized regression weight, β standardized regression weight, RW raw relative weight (within rounding error, raw weights will sum to R^2), CI-L lower bound and CI-U upper bound of confidence interval used to test the significance of raw weight, RS-RW relative weight rescales as a percentage of predicted variance in the criterion variable attributed to each predictor (within rounding error, rescaled weights sum to 100%). Helpful = Help is Useful, Enjoyable = Help Process is Enjoyable, Lessens = Help Diminishes Me, indePendence = Help Threatens My Independence, Safe = Helpers are Trustworthy. ¹There was one participant with missing data on the help-seeking measure. * $p < .05$

Table 3: Full Version of Table 5 in Manuscript with Standard Errors Reported
Hierarchical Regression Analysis

Predictor variables	Dependent variables									
	Help Seeking		Help Received		Life Satisfaction		Positive Affect		Negative Affect	
	Step 1	Step 2	Step 1	Step 2	Step 1	Step 2	Step 1	Step 2	Step 1	Step 2
Control variables										
Sex	.08 (.21)	.08 (.22)	.11 (.11)	.11 (.11)	.32 (.11)**	.31 (.11)**	.21 (.10)*	.21 (.09)*	.06 (.09)	.01 (.01)
Age	-.01 (.01)	-.01 (.01)	-.01 (.00)*	-.01 (.03)	-.01 (.00)	.00 (.00)	.00 (.00)	-.01 (.00)	.00 (.00)	.00 (.00)
Subjective SES	.11 (.06)	.09 (.06)	.21 (.03)**	.16 (.03)**	.20 (.03)**	.20 (.03)**	.13 (.03)**	.12 (.03)	-.03 (.02)	.00 (.00)
Self-esteem	.23 (.19)	.21 (.20)	.02 (.10)	.00 (.10)	.51 (.10)**	.43 (.10)**	.30 (.09)**	.24 (.09)**	-.33 (.08)**	-.27 (.08)**
Extraversion	.30 (.14)*	.30 (.15)*	.31 (.08)**	.28 (.08)**	.10 (.07)	.14 (.07)	.16 (.06)*	.18 (.06)**	-.01 (.06)	.00 (.01)
Agreeableness	.25 (.15)	.20 (.16)	.22 (.08)**	.25 (.08)**	.07 (.08)	-.03 (.08)	.22 (.07)**	.16 (.07)*	-.13 (.06)*	-.11 (.06)
Openness	-.03 (.13)	-.06 (.13)	-.03 (.07)	-.01 (.07)	-.05 (.07)	-.10 (.07)	-.08 (.06)	-.12 (.06)*	.14 (.05)**	.14 (.06)*
Conscientiousness	-.21 (.17)	-.20 (.18)	-.16 (.09)	-.20 (.09)*	.09 (.09)	.09 (.09)	-.02 (.09)	-.02 (.08)	-.13 (.07)	-.11 (.07)
Neuroticism	.21 (.19)	.25 (.16)	.15 (.08)	.21 (.08)*	-.02 (.08)	.00 (.08)	-.09 (.07)	-.08 (.07)	.21 (.07)**	.19 (.07)**
Independent variables										
Helpful		.11 (.18)		-.13 (.09)		-.07 (.09)		-.08 (.08)		.02 (.07)
Enjoyable		.04 (.17)		.26 (.08)**		-.10 (.08)		-.06 (.07)		-.11 (.07)
Lessens		-.01 (.21)		.07 (.11)		-.09 (.11)		-.14 (.09)		.03 (.09)
indePendence		.22 (.17)		.17 (.08)		-.13 (.08)		-.03 (.07)		.00 (.07)
Safe		.28 (.18)		.25 (.10)*		.21 (.10)*		.16 (.08)		-.04 (.08)
Model <i>F</i>	3.14**	2.33**	15.90**	12.40**	33.30**	23.95**	31.30*	21.73**	26.25**	17.58**
<i>R</i> ²	.13	.16	.44	.50	.62	.65	.61	.63	.56	.58
Adjusted <i>R</i> ²	.09	.09	.41	.46	.60	.63	.59	.60	.54	.55
ΔR^2		.02		.06**		.03**		.02*		.02

Note. Unstandardized regression coefficients. Standard errors for each unstandardized regression coefficient are reported in the parentheses. Helpful: Help is Useful, Enjoyable: Help is Enjoyable, Lessens: Help Diminishes Me, indePendence: Help Threatens my

Independence, Safe: Helpers can be Trusted. One participant had missing data for Help Seeking. Sex: Female = 1, Male = 0. * $p < .05$.
** $p < .01$.

References

- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2006). Using thematic analysis in psychology. *Qualitative Research in Psychology*, 3, 77–101.
- Braun, V., & Clarke, V. (2019). Reflecting on reflexive thematic analysis. *Qualitative Research in Sport, Exercise and Health*, 11(4), 589–597.
- Braun, V., Clarke, V., Boulton, E., Davey, L., & Mcevoy, C. (2021). The online survey as a qualitative research tool. *International Journal of Social Research Methodology*, 24(6), 641-654.
- Chenail, R. J. (2012). Conducting qualitative data analysis: Reading line-by-line, but analyzing by meaningful qualitative units. *Qualitative Report*, 17(1), 266–269.
<https://doi.org/10.46743/2160-3715/2012.1817>
- Geller, D., & Bamberger, P. A. (2012). The impact of help seeking on individual task performance: The moderating effect of help seekers' logics of action. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 97(2), 487–497. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0026014>
- Karabenick, S. A., & Knapp, J. R. (1991). Relationship of academic help seeking to the use of learning strategies and other instrumental achievement behavior in college students. *Journal of Educational Psychology*, 83(2), 221–230.
- Komiya, N., Good, G. E., & Sherrod, N. B. (2000). Emotional openness as a predictor of college students' attitudes toward seeking psychological help. *Journal of Counseling Psychology*, 47(1), 138–143. <https://doi.org/10.1037/AJ022-0167,47.1.138>
- Levitt, H. M., Bamberg, M., Creswell, J. W., Frost, D. M., Josselson, R. Suarez-Orozco, C. (2018). Journal article reporting standards for qualitative primary, qualitative meta-analytic, and mixed methods research in psychology: The APA publications and communications

- board task force report. *American Psychologist*, 73(1), 26-46.
- Merriam, S. B., & Tisdell, E. J. (2016). *Qualitative Research: A Guide to Design and Implementation*. Jossey-Bass: San Francisco.
- Saldaña, J. (2013). *The Coding Manual for Qualitative Researchers* (Second Edi).
<https://doi.org/10.1108/qrom-08-2016-1408>
- Thompson, P. S., & Bolino, M. C. (2018). Negative beliefs about accepting coworker help: Implications for employee attitudes, job performance, and reputation. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 103(8), 842–866. <https://doi.org/10.1037/apl0000300>
- Vaux, A., Burda, P., & Stewart, D. (1986). Orientation toward utilization of support resources. *Journal of Community Psychology*, 14(2), 159–170. [https://doi.org/10.1002/1520-6629\(198604\)14:2<159::AID-JCOP2290140207>3.0.CO;2-H](https://doi.org/10.1002/1520-6629(198604)14:2<159::AID-JCOP2290140207>3.0.CO;2-H)
- Vogel, D. L., & Wade, N. G. (2009). Measuring perceptions of stigmatization by others for seeking psychological help: Reliability and validity of a new stigma scale with college students. *Journal of Counseling Psychology*, 56, 301–308. <https://doi.org/10.1037/a0014903>
- Vogel, D. L., Wade, N. G., & Haake, S. (2006). Measuring the self-stigma associated with seeking psychological help. *Journal of Counseling Psychology*, 53(3), 325–337.
<https://doi.org/10.1037/0022-0167.53.3.325>